



» FIFA WORLD CUP SPOTLIGHT

THE MEN BEHIND THE MAGIC

The biggest stories at the FIFA World Cup were not written by players alone. Behind every surprise package stood a coach **willing to challenge** convention.

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Every FIFA World Cup is almost always remembered for the players who rise above the rest and emerge as the difference-makers. But behind those talented legs are the brains of a head coach who acts as the architect of the unimaginable, allowing an entire nation to dream beyond the impossible. The latest edition of the “greatest show on Earth” was no different.

Pedro Leitão Brito, more commonly known as Bubista, had spent over a decade representing

and leading a Cape Verde side that was merely making up the numbers, with little weight of expectation. But the turn of the decade saw Bubista return as a tactician and script one of the greatest World Cup stories ever.

He dedicated the better part of his tenure to scouting players from beyond the island nation, eventually assembling a 26-man squad that featured only 11 individuals born in Cape Verde. But then came the hard part. The Blue Sharks could easily have settled for being one of the beneficiaries of an expanded tournament. Instead, Bubista doubled down in training, focusing on improving endurance and intensity to sustain his side

Carving a niche: Much of Cape Verde’s remarkable World Cup campaign bore the imprint of Bubista, the former international who returned in January 2020 to transform a side content with making up the numbers into one capable of unsettling the world’s elite. AP

throughout matches.

Cape Verde eventually arrived in North America as a cohesive defensive unit that relied on individual moments of brilliance in attack. It held Spain, Uruguay and Saudi Arabia to draws in the group stage and sent a shiver through defending champion Argentina in the first knockout round before bowing out, having won hearts all around. Bubista’s emotions were summarised perfectly in his final meeting with the press: “More so than just playing, this was about showing the world our identity.”

Like Bubista, another coach who made a lasting impression was a man who enjoyed his own moment in the sun.

Hossam Hassan has been, and perhaps to some extent still is, the greatest player to wear Egypt’s badge, holding the all-time scoring record for the African nation. During his playing days, he thrived on physical battles and relentless intensity, traits he carried into management after stepping into the dugout.

Taking over the national side in 2024, Hossam already had a reputation for explosive outbursts. Surprisingly, however, that attitude proved to be exactly what was needed to unlock the team’s potential. Egos were quashed inside the dressing room, and selection was based purely on performance rather than stature.

This eventually allowed the record AFCON champion to banish its group-stage demons in its fourth appearance at the Finals, with Hossam overseeing every minute like a storm waiting to burst while his twin brother Ibrahim Hassan provided the calm. The pot, however, boiled over after Egypt’s